



India realised it late but towards the better. Today, the nation witnesses a paradigm shift in disaster management. The grand stage has been set, and the road maps gradually rolling out towards making India — a disaster-resilient nation. A Report.

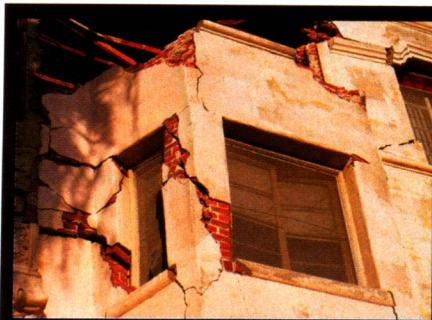
Hardly anyone can forget the Latur earthquake of September 30, 1993, Orissa Super Cyclone of October 1999, the Gujarat Earthquake of January 26, 2001 and many more. The blaring shrieks of tears and pain... the irremediable losses... Thousands lost their lives, and many more lost their kiths and kins; many were impaired for life while almost all were bereaved of their nest eggs. Even today, most disaster victims live with the heartrending recollections of these calamities.

These severe destructions, owing to nature's ruthless blows, time and again exposed the inadequate preparedness measures at all levels to contend with such major disasters in the country. And hence was realised the immense importance of instituting better preparedness and mitigation measures and response mechanism in India. And what we find today is a paradigm shift in the area, with a disaster intelligent and resilient community, duly empowered

by a newly created disaster management structure, working in cohesion multi-sectorally, so as to help realise the national vision of building a safer India.

A wait, worth it...

India took quite a number of years to wake up to the significance of establishing the requisite institutional mechanism for disaster management. The Indian Ocean Tsunami of December 26, 2004, acted as a catalyst for the national leadership to move into a high gear for passing the disaster management bill. On December 23, 2005, the Government of India took a defining step by piloting the enactment of the Disaster Management Act (DM Act 2005). This envisaged the creation of the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA), headed by the Prime Minister, and State Disaster Management Authorities (SDMAs) by the Chief Ministers, to spearhead and implement a



Hard facts —

- 30 per cent of the landmass in India is prone to earthquakes of moderate and 28.6 percent to high to very high intensity;
- Over 40 million hectares (12 per cent of land) is prone to floods and river erosion;
- Of the 7,516 km long coastline, close to 5,700 km is prone to cyclones and tsunamis;
- 68 per cent of the cultivable area is vulnerable to drought and hilly areas are at risk from landslides and avalanches.